

Omnivores

Most animals are either plant-eaters or predators and rarely change from their usual food. Instead of keeping to the same menu, omnivores eat anything edible they can find. They include a diverse range of animals, from cockroaches to the mighty brown bear, which is the world's largest omnivore, sometimes weighing more than half a ton. Whatever their size, omnivores are adaptable and adventurous and are ready to try foods they have not eaten before. Some omnivores have become successful at life in towns, where they thrive on leftovers that omnivorous humans throw away.

Fatal leap

Every spring, Alaska's brown bears wade into rivers during the annual salmon run, when adult salmon migrate upstream to spawn (produce eggs). It is a major event in the brown bear's calendar, because fish is a very nutritious food. Dozens of bears gather at fast-flowing rapids, grabbing salmon as they leap into the air. This yearly feast shows in the brown bear's size. Alaska's brown bears, or "grizzlies," are often twice as heavy as those that live in other regions, where there are few fish to catch.

Bear necessities

Brown bears live across the northern hemisphere. Their diet depends on the time of year and varies from place to place. In Alaska and on the coast of eastern Russia, brown bears get more than one-tenth of their yearly food from fish. They also eat other animals, including deer and huge numbers of insect grubs. Despite their hunting skills, plants make up about three-quarters of their food.

